

What Should SMBs Look for While Buying a Laser Printer?

Buying a laser printer doesn't involve rocket science, but for an IT head, making an informed choice is a must. This column explores the various aspects that IT heads should cover while buying a laser printer, particularly if they work at SMBs that have restricted IT budgets.

The Indian SMB market for printers accounts for over 50 million units, and is growing at a CAGR of 4.53 per cent. These are big figures, and printer makers are keenly watching this booming segment and coming up with products suited to the needs of SMB players. Laser printers, by virtue of being cheap (in terms of price), and offering just the kind of output and volumes that an SMB needs, are a favourite in this market segment. Printer makers, including Canon, HP and Xerox, have introduced products that cater to these buyers. Here, *OSFY* extends a helping hand to the IT heads of SMBs, to help them select the best laser printer.

But before we start with that discussion, let us understand why laser printers have become a popular choice. These printers are useful when you have to print a lot of documents at a fast speed. Of course, they don't offer top-quality photo prints, but are good for regular black text pages. Earlier, they used to be bulky, but over time, OEMs have reduced their sizes as well as cost. However, their toner cartridges are still expensive, but if you compare these with inkjet cartridges, the overall cost is pretty low as laser printers are able to produce many more prints.

There are quite a few aspects that an IT head needs to keep in mind while investing in a good laser printer for an SMB. We will try and sum these up for you.

- 1. Understand your needs:** First, evaluate the printing requirement that your set-up requires. Laser printers are good for text, but if your organisation typically needs to print more of graphics or pictures, an inkjet printer is a better option. Most laser printers available in the market today offer great printing quality for text. So, if you have to print text pages on a daily basis, a laser printer is a good option for you.
- 2. Printing load:** The printing load refers to the volume of printing required to be done at a regular interval. Gautam Paul, assistant director and head, consumer systems group (CSP), Canon India, shares, "An IT head has to look at the size of the office, which would, in a way, help in determining the printing load that the printer will have to eventually face. What kind of printer an SMB should invest in would largely depend on the number of users and their nature of work. Some employees may need to use the printer more frequently than the others. So, all these aspects should be looked into before making a choice."
- 3. Network connected or not?** While buying a laser

printer, consider whether it has to be used in a networked environment, where several users and computers are connected to it. If so, it has to be a robust model. However, if the printer to be purchased is to be used by a single person a model with a lower configuration would be adequate.

- 4. Do you need colour?** Some organisations have colour printing requirements, while the others can do without a colour printer. If you don't need a colour printer for a specific purpose, there's no point investing in one, as they are expensive to buy and to maintain.
- 5. Is refilling possible?** Since the cartridge of a laser printer is expensive, IT heads must ideally check the refilling options to ensure that their IT budgets do not spiral out of control while replacing the cartridges of laser printers. There are quite a few companies offering easy and affordable refilling options. These printers turn out to be more affordable and pocket-friendly in the long run compared to the ones where cartridges have to be replaced completely.

So, once IT heads are sure about these aspects, they can start hunting for that perfect device for their set-up. Apart from these aspects, there are quite a few technical aspects that must be looked into before making that final choice. Here are some basic printer technicalities to keep in mind.

- 1. Engine speed:** This denotes the time the printer takes to complete a printing job. It is generally denoted in pages per minute (ppm), characters per minute (cpm) or images per minute (ipm). One needs to be extremely careful while checking these claims as OEMs might mention the performance of the printer in the draft mode and not how it would perform in a standard real-world setting. Many a time, they even tend to omit the initial processing time that a printer takes before printing the first page in a given job. This is an unavoidable aspect of any printing job; hence, this time should be factored in while determining the engine speed of a printer. The engine speed may also vary depending upon the nature of a task. Printing graphics or dual-side printing (duplexing) does affect the speed of the printer.
- 2. Internal memory:** The internal memory of a printer denotes how much print data it can accumulate. It is expressed in kilobytes (KB) or megabytes (MB). However, not many printers have an internal memory.